that were set up in 1971 appeared in states away from the eastern border, in Bihar, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh.

The international engagement for relief work in 1971 was extensive. The Red Cross, Oxfam, Care, Caritas pitched in, as did the UNICEF, where Tarlok Singh was on deputation. American reluctance to support India due to its traditional support towards Pakistan complicated international affairs as India aggressively reached out to other countries to highlight the East Pakistan issue and the scale of the refugee crisis. One outcome was the constant stream of visits by foreign dignitaries to the refugee camps to see the problems first-hand. Another was India's appeal to the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) in April 1971 for assistance. The assistance finally provided was less than what India asked for but still extensive as it comprised important material for relief work, collected from around the world. Thousands of vehicles, tonnes of rice, polythene sheeting and blankets for three million people were provided at short notice. In one long airlift mission, 700 tons of medical supplies were flown over to India.

The refugee crisis could have lingered on for much longer if decisive action had not been ordered by India's then prime minister, Indira Gandhi (1917–84). In what remains her moment of crowning glory, the Indian army won a quick victory in December 1971 after months of resistance offered by Bengali separatists to the Pakistani army. Within a few weeks, ten million people returned to their land—Bangladesh. Camps were disbanded and nearly everywhere, officers noted that repatriation was 100 per cent complete. Within Bangladesh itself, the erstwhile migrants from India, or the muhajirs, found themselves stranded as they had lent support to the Pakistani army. Known even today as the 'stranded Pakistanis', they had succumbed to the fears expressed by the old man in *The Shadow Lines:* 'Where will you move to? No one will have you anywhere.'

India had played a stellar role in providing temporary shelter to 10 million people, managing world opinion to its advantage and opening a new relationship with its eastern neighbour that had seemed unfeasible before. But this also opened up new challenges. In his memoirs, former Reserve Bank of India governor and economic diplomat, I.G. Patel (1924–2005),